



PATH 05

A weekly AI letter

A list is the one asset a platform cannot take from you in an afternoon.

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Who this is for

You can write clearly once a week. You want an asset that compounds.

Time to first

2–4 weeks to a real list

Tools

First sale

Fifty honest subscribers and one reply that is not spam.

Cash window

Sells the playbook after trust

Leave this alone

Beehiiv or MailerLite, a one-page diagnostic as the lead magnet, a form.

Daily blasts. Buying a list. Essays nobody asked for.

What the letter is for

The letter is not a blog. It is a weekly appointment. One idea, one story, one ask. That is the whole shape. If you cannot say those three things about an issue before you write it, you do not have an issue yet.

A blog sits on a URL and waits. A letter arrives. The reader did not hunt for you that morning. You showed up in a place they already check: the inbox. That is why a list is the one asset a platform cannot take from you in an afternoon. A handle can vanish. An inbox you earned stays.

One idea, one story, one ask The idea is a single useful claim, small enough to finish in four hundred words. Not “how to use AI.” Something like “the follow-up I send twenty minutes after a call, and the two lines I never skip.” The story is one real moment that makes the idea true: a client who went quiet, a Tuesday you almost skipped, a prompt that failed until you added one constraint. The ask is one action. Reply with a score. Try the prompt. Forward this to the one person who keeps starting from a blank page. Not three actions. One.

AI drafts. You cut. You may let a model outline the issue or tighten a muddy paragraph. You may not let it publish. Cut until it sounds like you on a Tuesday. If you would not say the sentence to a person across a table, it does not go in the letter. The reader can smell a paste. They came for a person who does the job, not for a summary of a summary.

When you sell You sell inside the letter after they have heard from you enough to trust the voice. Email one is the diagnostic and the welcome. Emails 2–6 teach. Email 7 can ask. If you pitch in email one like a late-night ad, they leave. Trust is not a mood. Trust is six useful Tuesdays in a row.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you can write clearly once a week and you want an asset that compounds. You do not need a following. You need one job you can talk about without inventing a persona, and the discipline to show up on the same day.

You are a fit if You already explain things in messages, comments, or client notes, and people write back. You can keep a promise that is boring: same day, same length, same person.

You are also a fit if you already have (or will soon have) a \$47 playbook, a template, or a named package. The letter is how those things get sold without shouting.

Skip this path if You cannot keep a weekly date for four weeks. The letter dies from missed Tuesdays, not from a weak logo. Skip it if you want daily growth hacks, if you plan to buy a list, or if you only write when you have a launch. Skip it if you have never finished a result for anyone, including yourself. Teach after you have a scar. Not before.

If you need money this week, run a productized package first, then start the letter with the notes from that job.

The offer, named in one sentence

Write this before you pick a logo: “Every Tuesday I send one useful note to [specific person] about [named job], plus a free one-page diagnostic. After you have a few issues, you can buy the \$47 playbook if you want the full sequence. If not, you still get the letter.”

If you cannot fill the brackets, you do not have a letter. You have a mood.

The free thing is the door The lead magnet is a one-page scorecard or a 7-day checklist. It has to be useful even if they never buy. That is the deal you keep. A scorecard that tells them which step to skip this week is a door. A “free” PDF that is only a sales letter is a trap, and they will treat you like one.

Put the form on the same page as your paid offer, but second. Free first is how strangers become a list. The paid button can wait.

What you are not offering You are not offering a community, a course, a daily brief, or “all of AI.” You are offering a weekly appointment and one paid file when trust exists. Keep the sentence short enough to paste into a bio.

What ‘done’ looks like

Done for the first month is not a launch. Done is fifty honest subscribers and one reply that is not spam. Honest means they gave you an email because they wanted the next Tuesday, not because a pop-up lied.

The weekly bar - Same day every week. If you promised Tuesday, it leaves Tuesday. - Same length. Four hundred to seven hundred words. Long enough to teach one thing. Short enough to finish on a phone. - One ask at the end. Count them. If you have three, delete two. - A subject line a human would open. Not “Newsletter #4.”

The money bar Email 7 (or the quieter monthly issue) points to the \$47 playbook without a countdown clock or a fake scarcity line. A sale from a subscriber who has read you is done. A sale from a stranger who never joined the list is a different path. Do not mix them in your head.

If you have the fifty names, the weekly habit, and one real reply, you have a letter. Everything else is decoration.

How the money works

The letter is free. That is not a slogan. It is the business model. You do not charge for the appointment. You charge for the file after the appointment has earned the right.

What you sell, and when The first paid offer inside the letter is the playbook: \$47, theirs to keep. Not a subscription in month one. Not a \$297 cohort. You have no proof yet, and they have six issues of trust, not a year.

Emails 2–6 should not sell. They should make the playbook obvious without naming a cart. When you finally ask, the sentence is calm: the full sequence is \$47, and next Tuesday still arrives either way.

What you never do for money You never sell the list. You never rent it. You never buy someone else's. Deliverability is the business. One rented blast can train the inbox to treat you as junk, and you will not know until Tuesday stops landing.

A sponsorship can wait until you would run the ad even if they paid you nothing. If you would not, skip it.

The first 72 hours

You do not need a brand kit. You need issue one, a form, and a free file that works.

Hours 1–8: write the first issue by hand Pick the reader. Pick the one job. Write issue one without a model in the room. A story you actually lived, one idea, one ask. Then, if you want, run it through AI to tighten — not to inflate. Cut every sentence that sounds like a keynote.

Subject line for issue one: something they can picture. “The 20-minute follow-up I actually send” beats “Welcome to the letter.”

Hours 9–16: the free file and the form Build a one-page scorecard or a 7-day checklist. Seven questions that change the advice, or seven days that a tired person can actually do. Export a clean PDF. Put your name and a reply-to on it.

Open Beehiiv or MailerLite. Create one form. One field besides email is plenty: first name, or the job they do. Not a twelve-field survey. Connect the welcome that delivers the file at once. If the

file arrives tomorrow, you already taught them you are slow.

Hours 17–24: ten humans, not a launch Send issue one to ten people you know. Ask them to reply with the line that was useful. That reply is your subject-line research. Do not ask “did you like it?” Ask for the line. Put the form on the same page as your offer, but second.

By hour 72 you should have a live form, a working welcome, issue one in ten inboxes, and one sentence from a real person you can steal for the next subject line.

The path, step by step

Twelve steps. Do them in order. Skipping ahead to “write a better brand” is how letters stay imaginary.

Step 1. Promise one specific weekly note Name the day. Name the length. Name the person it is for. Keep it. Same day, same length. If you cannot keep Tuesday, do not print Tuesday on the form.

Step 2. Name the one reader Write one sentence about one person. Not “entrepreneurs.” A solo bookkeeper who hates the blank follow-up. A tradesperson who wants five posts without sitting on a phone. If two readers appear, you have two letters. Pick one.

Step 3. Build the diagnostic One page. Scorecard or 7-day checklist. Useful if they never buy. If you cannot use it yourself this week, it is not ready.

Step 4. Stand up the form Beehiiv or MailerLite. One form, one welcome, one tag if you must. Test from a second email. Confirm the file arrives and the unsubscribe works.

Step 5. Write issue one by hand Then optionally tighten with a model. Publish only the version that sounds like you.

Step 6. Subject lines that are specific “The 20-minute follow-up I actually send,” not “Newsletter #4.” Steal the useful line from those first ten replies. Specific beats clever. Clever dies in a promotions tab.

Step 7. End with one ask Reply, click, or try the prompt. Not three. The reply is the gold. A click is fine. A prompt they can run in five minutes is better than a survey.

Step 8. Teach for five issues Emails 2–6 are the job, in pieces. One piece per Tuesday. No cart. No “by the way I sell a thing” in paragraph two. You are earning the seventh email.

Step 9. The quieter ask Once a month, a quieter issue that points to the paid file. Email 7 can ask. Calm, priced, easy to ignore.

Step 10. Never buy a list. Never scrape Your deliverability is the business. Fifty names who open beat five thousand who never did.

Step 11. Turn replies into issues When someone writes “I get stuck after the call,” that is next Tuesday. The letter gets easier when you stop inventing topics and start answering mail.

Step 12. Keep the date for twelve weeks before you add anything No daily version. No second letter. Twelve Tuesdays. Then look at what they replied to, and only then consider a second product.

Worked example: Elena’s Tuesday letter

Elena used to coordinate jobs at a small studio. She was good at the twenty minutes after a client call: recap, next step, date. When she went solo, the blank follow-up came back. She wrote the sequence down so she would stop rewriting it. That file sat on her desktop for two months. Then she started a Tuesday letter so the file would have somewhere to live.

The promise Every Tuesday, one note for people who sell work from a kitchen table and freeze after the call. Four hundred to six hundred words. No daily blast, no “week in AI.” She named it after the day.

The door The free file is a one-page scorecard: seven questions about how they follow up, a score, and one next step. “Reply with your score and I will tell you which path to skip.” That line is in the welcome. She put the form above the \$47 button on her page. Free first.

The first four Tuesdays Issue one: the 20-minute follow-up she actually sends, with the two lines she never skips. She wrote it by hand, then asked a model to cut forty words, then put twenty back because the cuts had removed her. She sent it to ten people she had worked with. Four replied. Three quoted the same sentence about not asking “how are you” in sentence one if you already know. That sentence became the subject line of issue two.

Issues two through six taught the rest of the job: the recap template, the prompt that turns messy notes into a recap without sounding like a robot, what to do when they go quiet, how to close a loop on Friday. No pitch.

The ask Issue seven was quieter. She told the story of the desktop file. Then: “If you want the full sequence, it is \$47 and yours to keep. If not, see you next Tuesday.” Seven people bought in ten days. She had eighty-one subscribers. Not a viral moment. A letter.

Elena did not buy ads. She did not scrape. She asked those first ten, then asked each new subscriber to forward the diagnostic to one person who hates the blank follow-up.

Copy you can paste

Use these as drafts. Swap the job. Keep the calm.

Form headline Seven questions. A score. One next step.
Free even if you never buy. The Tuesday letter comes after.

Welcome (email one) Here is the one-page diagnostic. Reply with your score and I will tell you which path to skip. I write once a week, on Tuesday, about [job]. One idea, one story, one ask. If that is not useful, unsubscribe. I will not be sad, and you will not hear from me again.

Issue close (teaching weeks) If you try this, reply with the line that worked — or the line that died. I read them. See you next Tuesday.

Issue close (the ask) If you want the full sequence, it is \$47 and yours to keep. If not, see you next Tuesday.

Personal invite (send to ten people) I started a Tuesday letter for [person] who [job]. Issue one is the [specific thing]. If you want it: [form]. If you have two minutes, reply with the line that was useful. That is the whole ask.

Subject lines that behave The 20-minute follow-up I actually send Stop asking “just checking in” The recap I send before I open the next tab A 7-question score, not another pep talk What I cut from last week’s prompt

Bio line One useful Tuesday note about [job].
Free diagnostic at the link. No daily blasts.

Week-by-week

Assume you have a job and evenings. This is four weeks to a real list, not a media company.

Week 1: form plus issue one Day 1–2: write the diagnostic and issue one by hand. Day 3: Beehiiv or MailerLite, form, welcome, test-buy of the free file from a second email. Day 4: send issue one to ten people you know. Day 5–7: collect the useful lines. Do not redesign the header.

Week 2: issue two plus ten personal invites Send issue two on the promised day. Invite ten more humans with the personal copy, not a broadcast. If someone forwards you a kind reply, ask if you can use the line (no last name required).

Week 3: teach one path Issue three is one chapter of the job. No pitch. If you have the \$47 playbook drafted, do not mention the price yet. Mention the problem the playbook solves, in human words.

Week 4: a quiet ask for the paid file If you have sent four useful issues and you have a file that works, you may ask. If the file is not ready, keep teaching. A bad ask costs more than a late one. After week 4, the cadence is the job: same day, one idea, one story, one ask. Once a month, the quieter issue with the \$47 link.

Do not add a Friday bonus letter in month two because you felt guilty about a slow week. Guilt is not a publishing calendar.

The quality bar

A good issue can be read in four minutes and used in twenty. If they cannot use it this week, it was an essay.

The kitchen-table test Read the issue out loud. If you would not say it to one person at a table, cut it. Hype, throat-clearing, and “as you know” go first. Named tools and named steps stay.

The Tuesday test Would this still be true next Tuesday if a model version changed? Teach the job, not the button labels of

one chat window. You can name a tool. Do not marry a menu.

The AI test If you paste the issue back into a blank chat and it could have written the whole thing, you have not written it. Add the scar: what failed, what you still do, the sentence you almost sent. That is the part they cannot download for free.

One typo will not kill you. A voice that sounds like a press release will.

What to count (and what to ignore)

Count a short list. Ignore the rest for the first two months.

Count these - Honest subscribers. Fifty is the first milestone. Not a purchased fifty. - Replies that are not spam. One real reply is worth more than a 60 percent open rate with silence. - Issues sent on the promised day. A 12-for-12 streak beats a viral issue you cannot repeat. - Unsubscribes per issue. A few means people are reading. Zero can mean you are too bland to bother leaving. - Playbook sales from the list after the ask. Note the issue number. That is your sales page, whether you like the design or not.

Ignore these for now Follower count on the platform you used to announce the letter. Daily growth charts. Open-rate panic below a number you saw in a thread. Different tools count opens differently, and image-blocking will lie to you.

If fifty people are on the list, ten open, and two reply, you have a letter.

Objections you will hear (including your own)

“I do not have an audience.” You need ten people who will tell you the useful line. Audience is what the letter builds. It is not a prerequisite. Write issue one,

send it to ten names in your phone, stop waiting for permission from a feed.

“Email is dead.” It is not. It is quiet. Quiet is why it still works. The people who say it is dead are tired of blasts. Do not send blasts. Send a Tuesday.

“I should wait until I have the playbook perfect.” The letter can start with the diagnostic. The \$47 file can land in week 4. Waiting for perfect is how you miss twelve Tuesdays.

“People will copy me.” They might copy the structure. They will not copy the scar. Teach anyway.

“I write too slow.” Good. Slow is a filter. Four hundred honest words beat twelve hundred padded ones. Set a two-hour cap. When the cap hits, cut, do not expand.

“What if nobody replies?” Ask a better ask. “Was this good?” dies. “Reply with the line you would actually send” lives. Also: write to one person. Letters to a crowd get silence. Letters to a name get mail.

What this path feeds

The letter is not a side hobby. It is the pipe.

What it fills It sells the playbook after trust — that is the cash window on purpose. It also sells templates when you mention the filled example you used this week. It throws off service work when someone replies “can you just do this for me?” That reply is a package, not a free consulting hour. Put the price in the reply or send the cheaper file.

Affiliate mentions belong below the reasoning, never above it, and only for tools you still use. The letter can carry that link because the trust already exists. Do not turn Tuesday into a

tool dump.

What it needs It needs a door: a diagnostic and a form. It needs one paid file worth asking for. It does not need a membership, a chat room, or a second newsletter. Those come after the Tuesday habit is boring, which is the goal.

Mistakes that kill the letter

Writing for a crowd Writing for search engines instead of one person. The inbox is not Google. A keyword in the subject that no human would say is how you train them to skim.

Letting AI publish unedited. The first draft from a model is a pile of true-sounding sentences. Your job is to make it specific, short, and slightly uncomfortable, the way a real Tuesday is.

Breaking the Tuesday promise Changing the promise every week. Tuesday is follow-up, then Friday is branding, then you skip a week for a “personal update.” That is not a letter. That is a mood board with a send button.

Sending only when you have a launch. Then you are not a letter. You are a store that opens four times a year and wonders why the door sticks.

Daily blasts. Buying a list. Essays nobody asked for. Those three are how small senders become noise. Do not. A 40-field form, a welcome that is only a pitch, and hiding the unsubscribe all show up later as a deliverability problem you will blame on the tool.

Tools (keep this small)

Beehiiv or MailerLite. Pick one. Do not split the list. A one-page diagnostic as the lead magnet. A form. That is the stack.

Why these and not a maze You need a place that sends, tracks unsubscribes, and delivers a file. You do not need a customer-data platform, a

popup that follows people around, or five landing-page builders. One page with the form second and the paid button third is enough.

How to use AI here Draft and tighten. Not send. Not invent subscriber stories. Not write fake testimonials. If you use a model to outline issue two, you still rewrite every paragraph in the voice you would use at a table.

What to leave on the shelf Daily sending tools. Scrapers. Anything that promises you a list by Friday. The list you did not earn will not open.

Checklist

Print this. Tick it.

Before you send issue one - One reader, written in one sentence - One promised day and a length you can keep - Diagnostic: one-page scorecard or 7-day checklist, useful if they never buy - Beehiiv or MailerLite account, one form, welcome that delivers the file at once - Test from a second email: file arrives, unsubscribe works - Issue one written by hand, then tightened, then read out loud - Subject line a human would open - One ask at the end - Form on the same page as the offer, but second

The first month - Ten people you know received issue one - You collected the useful lines - Issues 2–6 teach; no cart in paragraph one - Once, a quieter issue that can point to the \$47 playbook - No list bought, no scrape, no daily extra

You may ask for money when - The free file works without you in the room - You have kept the day - You can say the price in one calm sentence

FAQ

How long should each issue be? Four hundred to seven hundred words. If you need two thousand, you have two issues. Split them. Tired people finish short letters.

Beehiiv or MailerLite — which one? Either. Pick the one you will actually log into. Switching later is a tax. Features you will not use are not a reason.

Can I send on Sunday if I promised Tuesday? No. Send Tuesday, even if it is shorter. If you must move the day, say so once, then keep the new day. Random is how they stop opening.

What if I have nothing to sell yet? Run the letter on the diagnostic for a month. Teach. Build the \$47 playbook from the replies. The list is still the asset. The cart can wait four weeks. It should not wait four years.

Should I add a podcast / YouTube / daily notes? Not until twelve Tuesdays have left on time. Extra channels are how letters starve.

Is fifty subscribers too small to ask for \$47? No. Elena asked at eighty-one and sold seven. Fifty honest names who have read you will outbuy five thousand quiet ones. Ask calmly. Do not apologize for the price.

What do I do with a mean reply? Unsubscribe them if they want out. If it is a real critique of the work, steal the useful part and ignore the heat. Do not write a Tuesday about your feelings unless that is the job you promised.

Can I use their reply in the next issue? Ask. “Can I use this line, no name?” Most people say yes. A few will want a first name. Do not invent a testimonial.

When do I buy ads to the form? After the welcome works, the diagnostic is useful, and you have at least four issues in the can.

What if I miss a week because life happened? Send a short note: “I missed Tuesday. Here is a short one. Back next week.” Then be back. Two misses in a row is a new habit.